FALL 2026 · A FIELD GUIDE

The State of the *American Apple*

Where they grow, what sells, what's healthiest, what tastes best, and what to buy this week.

Sources: USApple/USDA, Produce Business, Serious Eats, UMN, AppleRankings. Full list on the last slide.

Video & photos: MikeyMoose, Dietmar Rabich / Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA)

STATE OF THE CROP, 2026/27

263M

bushels of US apples

−7% vs. last year **−3%** vs. 5-year average

BY STATE · MILLION BUSHELS · CHANGE VS. LAST YEAR

Washington	~176M	−2% · about 2 of every 3 US apples
New York	~32M	−10%
Michigan	25M	−1%
All other states	~30M	(the rest)

~45M bu
exported (+2%)

~60%
of grower costs are labor

At or below cost
farm prices for several varieties

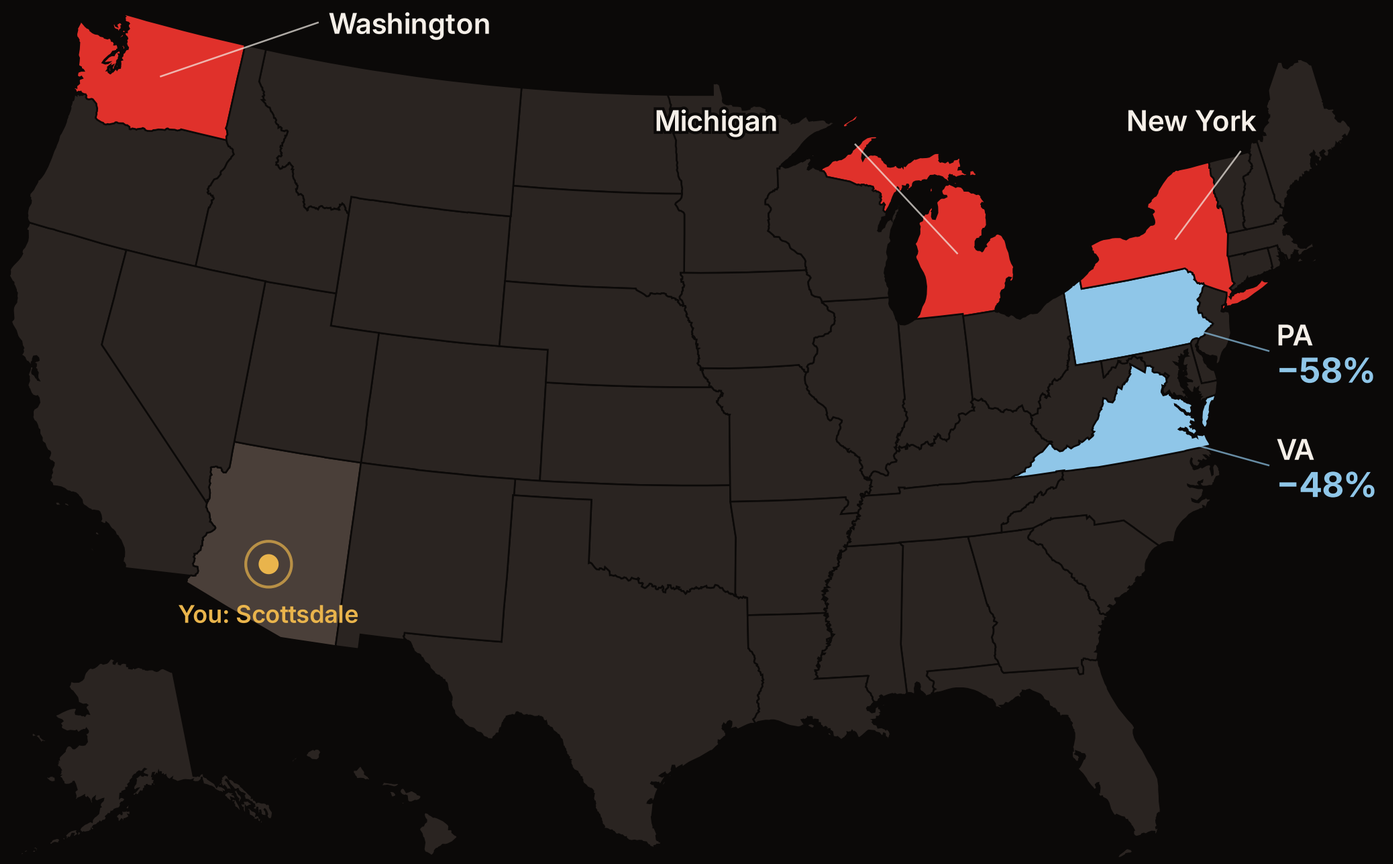
Sources: USApple/USDA 2026 Outlook (Aug 21, 2026; no final adjusted national number published); Commodity Marketing Board. "All other states" = national total minus the three named.



Photo: Dietmar Rabich / Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 4.0)

WHERE APPLES COME FROM

Three states grow most of it. A spring freeze hit two others.



Big three growers

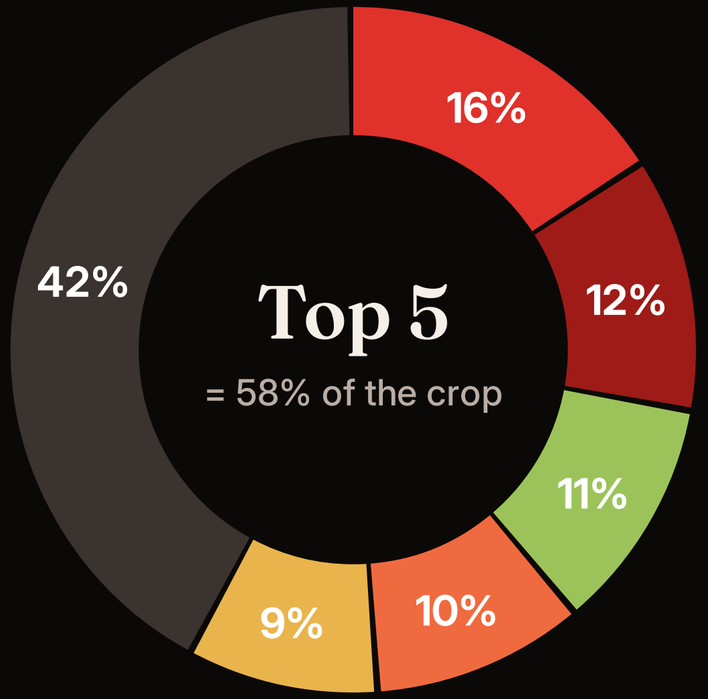
Hit by April freeze

A hard **April freeze** hit at bloom time and cut both crops roughly in half.

Sources: USApple/USDA 2026 Outlook (Aug 21, 2026); FreshPlaza. Map: US Census boundaries via us-atlas.

VOLUME VS. DOLLARS

Gala grows the most. Honeycrisp earns the most.



SHARE OF 2026 CROP VOLUME

Gala	16%
Red Delicious	12%
Granny Smith	11%
Honeycrisp	10%
Fuji	9%
Everything else	42%

RANK BY SALES DOLLARS

1. Honeycrisp
2. Gala
3. Granny Smith
4. Cosmic Crisp ~10% of sales

SALES GROWTH, 52 WEEKS TO JUNE 2026



Sources: USApple 2026 Industry Outlook (volume); Produce Business, "Washington Apples Regain Momentum" (sales).

HONEYCRISP: THE RISE AND THE HANGOVER

From reject to superstar to surplus

1960
The cross

Made at the University of Minnesota.

1977
Discarded

Tagged as a reject.

1982
Rescued

Pulled back and re-tested.

1988
Named

It gets the name Honeycrisp.

1991
Released

Out to growers and shoppers.

2008
Patent ends

Anyone can grow it.

Now
Overplanted

More trees than the market needs.

RISE

FALL

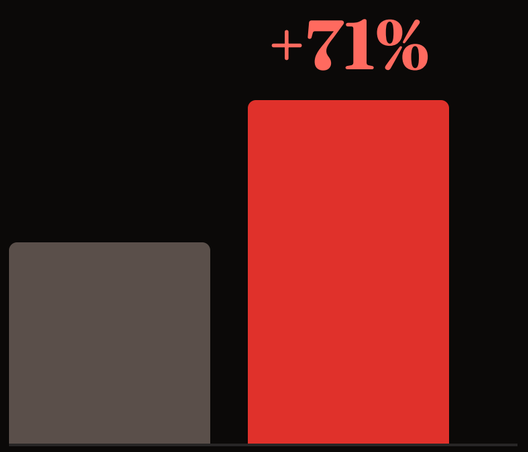
Sources: University of Minnesota (mnhardy.umn.edu/honeycrisp); Serious Eats, "How Honeycrisp Apples Went From Marvel to Mediocre".

Photo: MikeyMoose / Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 3.0)

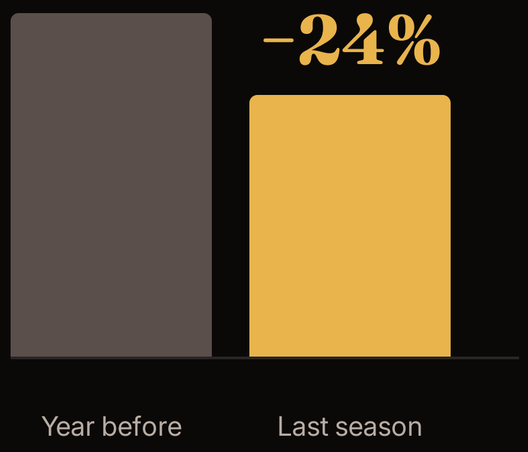
THE GLUT, IN NUMBERS

Too many apples, too little money

Supply vs. 5-year average



Grower prices, last season



> Shelf price around **$1.70/lb**, per Serious Eats. Good news for shoppers.

Sources: Serious Eats (surplus, ~$1.70/lb); Commodity Marketing Board (grower prices ~24% below prior year).



Photo: Quintin Soloviev / Wikimedia Commons (CC BY 4.0)

DIAGRAM

Why your Honeycrisp tastes so-so

1

Big, juicy cells

The famous snap. Cells burst with juice.

2

Grown warm

Planted big in Washington. Warm or overcropped fruit tastes "mild."

3

Stress shows

Bitter pit (brown spots), sunburn and bruising.

4

Long storage

Months in storage dull the flavor.

5

So-so apple

Mild, soft or spotty by the time you buy it.

Sources: Serious Eats; University of Minnesota (UMN); Tong et al. 1999.

Photo: MikeyMoose / Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 3.0)

THE FAMILY TREE

Honeycrisp's kids got its crunch



Honeycrisp

The parent of both



HONEYCRISP × ZESTAR!

SweeTango

Adds Zestar!'s tang.



HONEYCRISP × ENTERPRISE

Cosmic Crisp

Stays crisp for months: now the largest stored variety (7M+ bu). Washington-only until 2032.

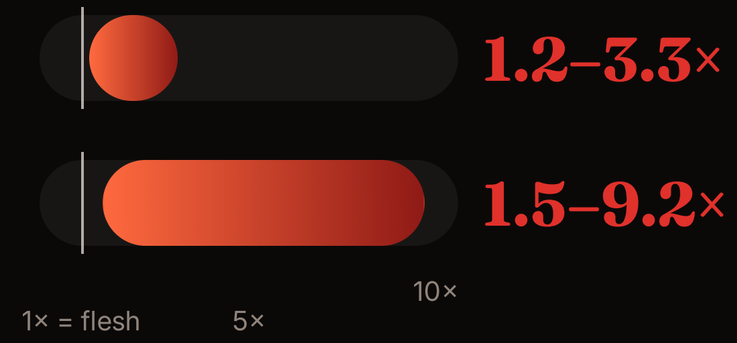
Club apples: licensed and grown under quality rules. SweeTango · Envy · Pink Lady · Cosmic Crisp · Kanzi · Opal

Sources: University of Minnesota; Tong et al. 1999; Produce Business; USApple 2026 Outlook.

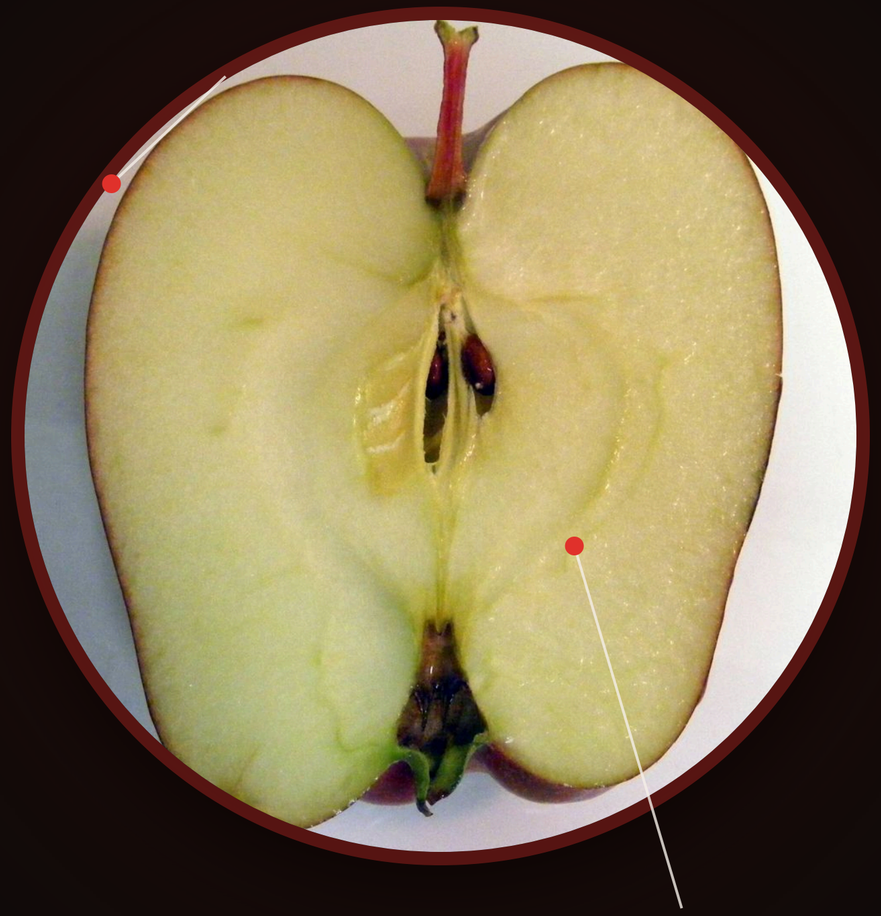
HEALTH

The good stuff is in the peel

HOW MUCH MORE THE PEEL HAS THAN THE FLESH



> Peeling costs you more than picking the "wrong" apple. You also lose most of the **~4 g** of fiber.



Sources: Drogoudi et al. 2008 (Scientia Horticulturae); 2016 peel/flesh study (Intl. J. of Fruit Science).

Photo: J.smith / Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 3.0)

TOP 5 HEALTHIEST

Darker skin, more antioxidants

1. **Red Delicious**
   Highest peel and flesh polyphenols in several studies.

2. **Granny Smith**
   Least sugar, lots of acid. Antioxidant rank varies by study.

3. **Pink Lady**
   Red-blush peel, solid phenolics. Tart, moderate sugar.

4. **Fuji**
   Middle of the pack on phenolics. Most sugar on this list.

5. **The one you'll actually eat**
   A daily apple beats the "perfect" one you skip.



Sources: Chile study (doi 10.4067/S0718-58392010000400001); Greek study (Drogoudi 2008); 2016 flesh study; Turkish CUPRAC study (J Sci Food Agric).

Photo: Sonita Lewis / Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 2.0)

TOP 5 BEST TASTING

Sweet-tart beats plain sweet

1	SweeTango	97	Bright and tangy.
2	Honeycrisp	95	Juicy and sweet, with low acid.
3	Kanzi	93	Very tart, very crisp.
4	Envy	86	Sweet, dense, slow to brown.
5	Pink Lady / Cosmic Crisp	86	Firm and crisp. Cosmic was runner-up in a Globe and Mail reader vote.

AppleRankings scores (out of 100), plus reader votes. Bars start at 70 to show the gaps.

Sources: AppleRankings (Brian Frange) via Food & Wine and WBUR Here & Now (Oct 6, 2026); The Globe and Mail reader vote.

Photo: Dennis Bratland / Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 3.0)

BUY THIS WEEK IN SCOTTSDALE

Your October shopping list

1

SweeTango

Grab it now at Sprouts, Whole Foods, Fry's or AJ's. Short season: gone by about November.

2

Fresh Honeycrisp

The fall 2026 crop is just picked: best time of year to buy. Choose firm fruit with no brown spots.

3

Cosmic Crisp

The safe pick if SweeTango is sold out.

!

Fridge, not counter

Arizona heat softens apples fast on the counter.

Sources: research brief, Oct 13, 2026; University of Minnesota; Serious Eats.

Photo: Danielle Scott / Wikimedia Commons (CC BY-SA 2.0)

SOURCES

Where the numbers came from

USApple, 2026 Industry Outlook Report (Aug 21, 2026): usapple.org/news-resources/usapple-releases-2026-industry-outlook-report

Serious Eats, "How Honeycrisp Apples Went From Marvel to Mediocre": seriouseats.com/how-honeycrisp-apples-went-from-marvel-to-mediocre-8753117

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Food & Wine, apple varieties ranked: foodandwine.com/best-apple-varieties-ranked-11822723

WBUR Here & Now (Oct 6, 2026): wbur.org/hereandnow/2026/10/06/apples-ranking

The Globe and Mail reader vote: theglobeandmail.com/life/style/food-and-drink/article-best-apple-varieties-vote/

University of Minnesota: mnhardy.umn.edu/honeycrisp

Tong et al. 1999, Honeycrisp softening in storage: experts.umn.edu/en/publications/comparison-of-softening-related-changes-during-storage-of-honeycr/

Chile study, Red Delicious peel: doi.org/10.4067/S0718-58392010000400001

Drogoudi et al. 2008: sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0304423807002993

2016 peel/flesh study: tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/15538362.2016.1262304

Turkish CUPRAC study: scijournals.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1002/jsfa.5810

Photos: Wikimedia Commons, by MikeyMoose, Dietmar Rabich, Quintin Soloviev, J.smith, Sonita Lewis, Danielle Scott, Dennis Bratland (CC BY / BY-SA). Map: us-atlas (US Census).

Links checked Oct 13, 2026. Publisher links for the three journal studies were found via search, not opened.